



DAVID SHAW
MAY 27TH, 2024





AMUSE BOUCHE

Asparagus and Fennel Soup with Cipollini Onion,
Chives, and Italian Saba Dressing

OYSTER AND CAVIAR

Glazed Oysters with Osetra Caviar, Leek Fondue,
Zucchini Pearls, and Lettuce Cream

LOBSTER RISOTTO

Risotto with Lobster, Rock Shrimp,
Shimeji Mushrooms, and Spring Vegetables

SCALLOP

Seared Scallops with Japanese Sweet Potato,
Rosemary, and Yuzu

LAMB LOIN

Herb Crusted Lamb Loin with Eggplant Zucchini Tian,
and Creamy Polenta

CHEESE SELECTION

Morbier, Camembert de Normandie, Époisses de Bourgogne, and Roquefort
Served with bread and grapes

CITRUS TART

Citrus Tart Lemon Curd, with Mandarin Mousse, and Goat Milk Sorbet

PAVLOVA MERINGUE

Pavlova Meringue with Passionfruit Crèmeux,
Mango Mousse, and Coconut Sorbet

MILLE-FEUILLE

Hazelnut Mille-Feuille, Caramelized Puff Pastry, Hazelnut Cream,
and Caramel Glazed Vanilla Ice Cream

BIRTHDAY CAKE

Cherry Chocolate Mousse Cake

PETIT FOURS

Almond Financier, Pecan Praline, Canele, Coconut Lemon Cake,
Strawberry Pate de Fruits, Chocolate Ganache, and Lemon Tart

FAREWELL GIFT

Pineapple Breakfast Muffin Cheesecake

Perhaps one of the greatest fears of a fine dining aficionado is to have a birthday on a Monday. Nearly all the restaurants in San Francisco that I was eager to pay a visit to were closed on Mondays, and the only option that looked decent enough was this place called Gary Danko. Years ago, when I frequently traveled to New York, I criticized several restaurants for being too conservative. I praised California restaurants for their consistent creativity, especially during the pandemic. Now, after living in California for nearly a year, I've observed a lot of superficial creativity and hypocrisy. Many chefs here adopt trendy cuisine styles without truly understanding them, as they lack deep knowledge of the cuisines they mimic. Now, I find myself longing for a cozy, decent classical French dinner to feel just comfortable.

It was fascinating to find out that Gary Danko shared its birth year with me. Upon entering the restaurant, I was quickly enveloped by its classical, old-money atmosphere, evoking memories of Manhattan. We started with a drink at the bar while waiting for our table. Shortly after, we were escorted into the left dining room where a cozy corner table awaited us, specially reserved by the maitre d'. Though not expansive, the dining room's ambiance captivated me so thoroughly that its size no longer mattered. A male waiter arrived with an extensive wine list and the menu. Having already studied it thoroughly, we were set on enjoying the four-course prix-fixe menu.

Meanwhile, an amuse-bouche dish arrived. It was a warm asparagus and fennel soup with cipollini onions, chives, and Italian Saba dressing. The end of May may sound warm but here in San Francisco it was still freezing cold at night, and thus we were particularly grateful to see such a soup served right away. The asparagus and fennel melted together just beautifully, and the saba condiment is just a nice touch to the medley. Sometimes called mosto cotto or vin cotto, saba is a condiment made from boiling down must, the grape smush left over from making wine. It has sweetness, depth, and complexity like a good balsamic, but still plenty of acid to balance.

They gave us plenty of time to enjoy the soup before taking the order. The menu at Gary Danko offers great flexibility—you can choose anything you like without worrying whether it's an appetizer or main course; you can even order all desserts if you prefer. However, this flexibility led to some confusion when placing our order. The middle-aged white waiter displayed a certain level of arrogance and had difficulty understanding our preferences. I tried to order according to the sequence of courses to emphasize pairings and ensure they were served in the desired order. Despite this, the waiter insisted on taking orders one person at a time. As my partner opted to skip the cheese course, I planned to order two desserts for her. However, due to the waiter's stubbornness, he simply could not comprehend this unconventional request and repeatedly took incorrect orders.





This petit interlude certainly didn't spoil our dinner. Without any delay, the two appetizers arrived. It was somehow unusual to start with two warm appetizers, especially when we already had a warm soup as amuse bouche. Yet, the evening's chill forced our choice for warmth. The glazed oyster with caviar, a hallmark of Gary Danko, captivated us with its velvety texture and the mellow warmth that embraces both the oceanic indulgence of the oyster and the pastoral peacefulness of the leek. Whether an original concept to adopt the duo of oyster and caviar unconventionally in a warm broth or a nod to Thomas Keller's signature dish, the dish was flawless. Adding to the richness, zucchini pearls and lettuce cream further enriched the fondue with green hues and delicate vegetable flavors. Perhaps one petit thing that evoked my slight unpleasantness was the micro oyster shell in the soup.

Meanwhile, a lobster risotto further excited us with its smart twist on oriental and Italian beauteousness. In a rather large bowl served a huge portion of risotto with lobster, rock shrimp, shimeji mushrooms, and spring vegetables. The execution of the risotto and the marriage of all the ingredients were impeccable, it was true to say that there were not many challenges in this dish, yet the fine touch of shimeji mushroom and the gentle balance of the crustaceans and the vegetables set the dish beyond ordinary comfort risotto dish.



A shortened menu may confront the reality that the climax arrived too soon, catching diners somehow less prepared. The scallop and lamb loin main courses swiftly appeared on the table, creating a peculiar sensation as if they were still appetizers. However, the somewhat rustic American style and large portion reassured that these were indeed the main dishes. The scallop dish was tremendously unbalanced in terms of portion ratio. Titled scallops, the dish indeed featured seared scallops, yet the Japanese sweet potato almost recreated the catastrophic avalanche scene, the worst kind that humans can ever imagine. The gargantuan sweet potato devoured everything so easily that the scallops were just like micro planktons that passed through a whale's mouth. The heavy sweetness of the sweet potato caused the rosemary and yuzu to be almost undetectable, not to mention the intrinsic mellowness of the scallop.

The lamb loin dish was spared from the portion issue, but the rusticity of the rural setting was an even worse concern. Herb-crusted lamb loin with eggplant zucchini and creamy polenta sounded marvelous, yet the reality would be equal to removing layers of makeup from a fake celebrity. The tian was prepared in a way not much different from local diner veggies that are simply poached, let alone the poorly refined lamb loin covered with nonchalant herbs.

Our misfortune in the main dishes was soon saved by the cheese course. It is almost a nostalgic thing to have a traditional cheese carte now, and I was glad to spot one at Gary Danko. As a matter of fact, Gary Danko was famous for its cheese carte, and almost every diner would not want to miss this fine selection of cheese. The same guy who caused fusses when ordering the menu came to greet us, now in a much more humble and gentle manner. I picked Camembert de Normandie, Époisses de Bourgogne, and Roquefort from the selection, and with his suggestion, Morbier was added to the lineup. Served casually with bread and grapes, the cheese plate was literally gigantic. I always enjoy the contrast of Normandie and Époisses, two extremely refined and melting soft cheeses exhibiting such a contrast in terms of robustness. Normandie was like a gentle kiss from the angle while the Époisses was akin to a masculine kabedon gesture from a knight. Roquefort was less pungent than what I can recall, while the Morbier was surprisingly good with a condensed texture while carrying aromas of ashes and smokes and a subtle taste in general.

Now, the stubbornness of this gentleman finally resulted in a big blow to our plans. Three desserts appeared at once on the table, following closely in the footsteps of the cheese course. It was as if we had never emphasized ordering four courses per person, as if we could have all the desserts at once like a foolish giant who didn't really care about digesting the details of the tastes, as if the restaurant didn't care if the ice creams melt and the final ice cream would just be liquid cream by the time we move on to the final dessert.

As a result, not only did I have to set the cheese plate aside to save the ice cream first, but I also had to rush to push everything into my mouth just to prevent the compositions from collapsing. The lemon tart was classic, and I would praise the goat milk ice cream for pulling me back to the mood of digesting cheese. The tartness and sharp acidity carried on to the Pavlova meringue with passionfruit crèmeux, mango mousse, and coconut sorbet, which in addition brought in hues of tropical fruitiness. The mille-feuille surprisingly resembles palmiers, and the medley of caramel, hazelnut, and vanilla just created a vortex that sucks people in with this irresistible dark sweetness.







It would take even cheese aficionados like myself a great amount of time to finish the cheese plate after three dessert courses. Now, as I did not have to worry about melting ice cream anymore, I finally had the time to reassess each cheese slice I ordered and surprisingly I got to taste more from them. There was a paragraph I loved when Gary Danko described the Morbier cheese, and here I quote: “Raw cow’s milk aged between one and two months, full of flavor and one of our favorite “stories” on the cart. The Shepard’s of the Franche-Comté hiking up the steep terrain would separate the morning milk from the evening milk with a tasteless layer of ash to avoid the possibility of wasting the excess curd. An oft-requested cheese, Morbier will always have a home on our cart. Alternatives may include, Tomme de Savoie, Tomme Crayuese, Lou Bergier Pichin, and more.”

I ordered a glass of one of the rarest Madeira I could imagine, a 1927 bastardo. It is not only just the sole vintage you could ever find but also a rare grape that is rarely seen since Phylloxera. Carrying a yet feminine bouquet of tangerine, beeswax, and dandelion, the Madeira tasted so much younger than I expected. It is almost linear in my sense and a yet-to-be-matured dates aroma seems dominating as well, along with a mesmerizing taste of orange marmalade, lemon peel, and sweet spices like nutmeg.

Now that I’ve finished eating and drinking, it took them much longer to notice that we’d been waiting for a while. I almost felt like I had ample time to sneak out and have another dinner at the neighboring restaurant. After an eternity, a waiter, who seemed skeptical, finally arrived, asking if everything was okay. I sarcastically replied that more should be coming, which seemed to surprise him. He offered to check in the back. Without delay, the petit fours and a to-go present arrived. It was indeed a spectacular yet somewhat unsophisticated lineup, featuring an almond financier, a pecan praline, a poorly made canelé, a coconut lemon cake, a strawberry pâte de fruits that tasted like hawthorn, a rather dense chocolate ganache, and a redundant lemon tart since we had just had one as the main dessert.

The farewell gift turned out to be a pineapple breakfast muffin cheesecake. Carrying a lot of stuff, we forged ahead, with a medley of complex feelings. Did Gary Danko fulfill my wish for a decent French dinner? To some extent, yes, yet the unprofessionalism was unforgivable.

